



concrete extensively, constructing many large-scale engineering and building projects.

The coming of the Republic

Rome was ruled by seven kings before the last one, the Etruscan Tarquinius, was overthrown in 509 BCE in a coup staged by Roman aristocrats. Rather than install a new monarch, the Romans dismantled the institution and Rome became a republic.

The early republic had two consuls (to counter overreliance on one individual), who were elected annually. While the Senate was originally put in place to prevent despotism, it became the true decision-making authority. The law was upheld by magistrates, who also came from the Senate. These public figures were expected to show loyalty to the republic, self-sacrifice for the general good, and lead blameless lives as an example to others.

Citizens and slaves

Roman republican society was divided into the free and non-free (slaves). The most significant free people were citizens, who were able to elect the consuls. Citizens were further divided into Patricians (an elite landowning class), and Plebeians (all other citizens). The Senate drew its members from the Patrician class; therefore, the Republic in its early form

was largely a transfer of power from the king to the wealthiest classes in Rome. Rising Plebeian resentment at this often led to violence in a class conflict that became known as the “struggle of the orders.”

The Patricians relied on the Plebeians, as they not only produced the food and supplied the labor that drove the Roman economy, but also formed the ranks in the Roman army (see pp. 114–115). This reliance led the ruling classes to bring about social reforms. These included the “Twelve Tables” laws (most of the evidence of these laws is now lost to us), the election of the first Plebeian Council in 366 BCE, and the passing of a ruling in 287 BCE that the Plebeian Council’s decisions would henceforth be binding for all citizens, including the Patricians. Rome’s

non-free people were slaves. From the 3rd century BCE the Romans used slave labor on a large scale for building projects.

Military success

Roman armies won extensive lands for the Republic in wars that gradually took place farther afield and with increasing scale. By 264 BCE, Rome emerged from clashes

with surrounding communities to dominate Italy, and by 146 BCE Rome had crushed the Carthaginians (see box left) in the Punic Wars, which broke out several times in the 3rd and 2nd centuries BCE, to dominate the entire western Mediterranean.



Young boy and boar
Figurine of a young Roman boy in a tunic leading a sacrificial boar. This boy was probably a slave or attendant.

Mixing business and ritual

This relief of the 1st century BCE shows animals being sacrificed to mark a census of citizens, which was done every few years. The figure in the toga (right of altar) is probably the censor (the magistrate taking the census).

The Romans’ treatment of conquered peoples varied greatly. To those who seemed to them “civilized” enough and close in kinship, they granted rights similar to those of Roman citizens. Those who actively resisted them received much harsher treatment. Both these approaches were seen as effective ways of enforcing power and influence.

REPUBLIC A society not ruled by a monarch in which power is shared between the aristocracy and the common people. The modern term is taken from the Latin *res publica*: “the public thing.”

Mounting problems

Despite its extensive lands, by the 2nd century BCE, Rome was in a state of perpetual war, flux, and social discontent. Farms fell into disrepair while their owners were away fighting, and debts were mounting. While the city of Rome was at the heart of a growing empire, tensions arose as the republic’s existing social and political institutions struggled to address new problems. The tensions reached a peak in 137 BCE when the Gracchi brothers, Tiberius and Gaius (tribunes of the Plebeians, or officials who represented Plebeian interests), pitted themselves against the Patrician Senate by proposing revolutionary social reform that included redistributing public land to the landless poorer classes. Armed struggle broke out and both brothers ended up dead. It was an episode that signaled the beginning of the Roman Republic’s decline.

The Roman Republic experienced great conflict in the 1st century BCE.

TIME OF TURMOIL

The 1st century BCE saw a mix of new gains and intensifying civil strife. Some of Rome’s former allies, having fought for the republic, became frustrated by Rome’s domination over them and failure to grant them Roman citizenship.

SULLA’S DICTATORSHIP

The years 82–80 BCE brought the self-proclaimed **dictatorship of Sulla**. His struggles with rival Marius had already weakened the republic and



THE DEATH OF SPARTACUS

his rule increased patrician (upper class) power. During his dictatorship there were heightened levels of corruption within the Senate.

THE SLAVE REVOLT

In 72–71 BCE, Spartacus, a former auxiliary in the Roman army turned slave-gladadiator, became **leader of a group of disaffected**

slaves and rebels (see above) that swelled to around 120,000; they fought the Romans and dominated much of southern Italy. The Romans were ultimately victorious and **Spartacus was killed** in around 70 BCE. However, the uprising showed the dangers of employing slave labor on a massive scale.

Senators

Members of the Senate were men of considerable personal wealth and standing and wore a toga with a broad stripe (*tunica laticlavata*).

Equestrians

These were upper/middle class men of wealth, often described as “knights.” They wore a toga with a narrow stripe (*tunica angusticlavata*).

Plebeians

The common “class” included every freeborn male citizen not a senator or equestrian. It varied from the unskilled poor to wealthy merchants.

Latins

Latins were freeborn citizens from parts of Italy outside Rome. They had certain legal rights and were granted a form of Roman citizenship.

Foreigners

Freeborn inhabitants of Roman territory outside Italy were considered foreigners. They were granted a form of citizenship in the 3rd century CE.

Freedmen

Slaves who had been “manumitted” (liberated, via a specific ceremony, by their masters). They had rights, but their status changed over time.

Slaves

The non-free who had no rights and were bought and sold by their owners. Slaves were considered personal property under Roman law.

Roman social order

Roman society had strict class divisions. These were influenced by family background, wealth, citizenship, and freedom. The system frequently sparked controversy and dissent. Women had virtually no rights and belonged to the same class as their father or husband.

AFTER

